

Connecting Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp and Google

Bring every customer message — and every new Google review — into one inbox. Set up once, by you, on your own accounts.

AUDIENCE

Whoever administers your Facebook Page

HANDS-ON TIME

≈ 60 minutes

THEN A WAIT

App Review, 1–7 days

Contents

You are connecting four things, and they are genuinely separate. Messenger, Instagram and WhatsApp each need their own step, though all three run through one Meta app that you create and own. Google reviews is not Meta at all and shares none of that work — if reviews are all you want, step 9 stands alone. Otherwise work through this in order: later steps depend on values produced by earlier ones.

-
- 1 **Before you start** — the four things that stop this dead
 - 2 **Create your Meta app**
 - 3 **Connect the webhook** — where messages arrive
 - 4 **Add Messenger** — your Facebook Page
 - 5 **Add Instagram**
 - 6 **Make a permanent access token**
 - 7 **Enter everything into your CRM**
 - 8 **Add WhatsApp** — a separate number, a separate token
 - 9 **Add Google reviews** — not messaging, same inbox
 - 10 **Test it end to end**
 - 11 **Go live: App Review**
 - 12 **When something is wrong**
 - 13 **Keeping it working**
-

Read this before you open anything

Four things will stop you, and three of them are not fixable in the moment

You must be a full admin of the Facebook Page. Editor is not enough. If someone else set the Page up, get admin access first.

Instagram must be a Professional account and linked to that Page. A personal Instagram account cannot receive messages through any system. Converting it is free and takes two minutes, but it must be done before step 5.

The WhatsApp number must not be in use on the WhatsApp app. A number registered to WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business on a phone cannot be used by the API. You need a number you can receive an SMS or a call on, that is not already a WhatsApp account. This surprises people at step 8, an hour in.

Until App Review passes, only people you list as testers can message you. Everything will look connected and work perfectly for you, and a real customer will get nothing. Step 11 covers this. Budget a week.

1 Before you start

Gather these now. Hunting for them mid-flow is where mistakes happen.

WHAT	WHERE IT COMES FROM	NEEDED FOR
A Facebook account with admin on your Page	Your Page → Settings → Page access	Everything
A Meta Business account	business.facebook.com — free	Steps 2, 6
Instagram Professional account, linked to the Page	Instagram app → Settings → Account type	Step 5
A phone number not on WhatsApp	Any number you can receive SMS or a call on	Step 8
Your CRM address	The address you sign in at	Step 3
Access to Settings → Integrations in the CRM	Your CRM administrator	Step 7

What you are actually building

A Meta app is not a program you write. It is a set of permissions and a delivery address: it tells Meta "this business is allowed to read and send messages for this Page, and messages should be delivered *here*". The address is your CRM. Nothing is installed anywhere.

You will end up with **four values** to copy into the CRM, and one value to copy *out* of it. Keep a notepad open — several are shown once and never again.

Do this on a desktop

Meta's developer console is not usable on a phone, and you will be copying long tokens between two browser tabs. Have your CRM open in one tab and **developers.facebook.com** in the other.

2 Create your Meta app

One app carries Messenger, Instagram and WhatsApp. You only do this once.

1. Go to **developers.facebook.com** and sign in with the Facebook account that administers your Page.
2. Click **My Apps** → **Create App**.
3. For "What do you want your app to do?", choose **Other**, then **Next**.
4. For app type, choose **Business**. This is the type that can hold Messenger, Instagram and WhatsApp together.
5. Give it a name your colleagues will recognise — "*Denago CRM connection*", not "*test*". Customers never see this name.
6. Select your **Business account**. If the dropdown is empty, create one at business.facebook.com first and come back.
7. Click **Create app** and re-enter your password when asked.

Copy the App Secret now

In the left sidebar go to **App settings** → **Basic**. You will see **App ID** and **App Secret**. Click **Show** beside the secret and copy it somewhere safe.

This is the value the CRM uses to prove a webhook really came from Meta and not from someone pretending. You will paste it in at step 7.

The App Secret is a password

Anyone holding it can impersonate Meta to your CRM. Do not paste it into email, a chat message, or a shared document. Copy it straight from Meta into the CRM at step 7, then clear your clipboard.

3 Connect the webhook

This is the address Meta delivers messages to, and the shared secret that proves it is really your CRM.

Do this *before* adding Messenger or Instagram. Both of those ask you to subscribe to fields, and the subscription only works once the address itself is verified.

First, get the two values from the CRM

In the CRM, open **Settings** → **Integrations**. Under **Facebook & Instagram (Meta)** you will find:

FIELD	WHAT TO DO
Webhook callback URL	Copy it exactly. It ends in <code>/api/webhooks/meta</code> .
Verify token	Reveal it and copy it. If it is empty, click Regenerate to create one.

The verify token is invented by your CRM, not by Meta. It is a password the two systems share so that Meta can prove it is talking to the right place. It does not need to mean anything.

Then register it with Meta

1. In your Meta app, left sidebar → **Webhooks**.
2. In the dropdown choose **Page**, then **Subscribe to this object**.
3. **Callback URL**: paste the URL from the CRM.
4. **Verify token**: paste the verify token from the CRM.
5. Click **Verify and save**.

Meta immediately calls your CRM to check the token. If it matches, the dialog closes and the subscription is created. If it does not, you get "*The URL couldn't be validated*" — the token does not match. Copy it again, carefully; a trailing space is the usual cause.

Subscribe to the right fields

With **Page** still selected, click **Subscribe** next to each of these:

FIELD	WHY
messages	Required. The customer's actual messages.
messaging_postbacks	Required. Taps on buttons and quick replies.
message_echoes	Recommended. Messages your team sends from Meta's own inbox also appear in the CRM, so the history is complete however it was answered.
message_deliveries	Optional. Delivered status under your sent messages.
message_reads	Optional. Seen status under your sent messages.
leadgen	Only if you run Facebook lead ads. Delivers the form straight into the CRM as a lead.

Subscribing to more than you need is harmless

Events the CRM does not use are ignored. It is better to subscribe now than to come back later wondering why delivery ticks never appeared.

4 Add Messenger

Attach your Facebook Page to the app, so the app is allowed to act for it.

1. In your Meta app, left sidebar → **Add product**.
2. Find **Messenger** and click **Set up**.
3. Scroll to **Access Tokens** (older consoles call this *Generate token*).
4. Click **Add or remove Pages**.
5. Choose the Page you want the CRM to answer for, then **Continue**.
6. Leave every permission ticked and click **Save**. Removing one here causes a permission error later that is very hard to trace back to this screen.

Your Page now appears in the list with a **Generate token** button. **Do not use it**. That token expires — sometimes in an hour, sometimes in two months — and when it does, messages stop arriving with no warning and no error anywhere you would think to look. Step 6 makes a permanent one instead.

Link the webhook to this Page

Still on the Messenger settings screen, find the **Webhooks** section. Your Page should be listed. If there is an **Add subscriptions** button next to it, click it and tick the same fields from step 3.

This catches people out: subscribing the *app* to Page events (step 3) and subscribing *this Page* to the app are two different actions, and both are required. If messages never arrive and everything else looks right, this is the first place to check.

5 Add Instagram

Instagram messages ride on the same connection, but must be switched on in two places.

Check these first, or the screens below will be empty

Your Instagram account must be a **Professional** account (Business or Creator), and it must be **linked to the Facebook Page** from step 4. Check in the Instagram app: **Settings** → **Account type and tools**, then **Settings** → **Sharing to other apps** → **Facebook**.

Allow the CRM to see messages

1. Open the Instagram app → your profile → **Settings**.
2. Go to **Privacy** → **Messages** (some versions: **Message controls**).
3. Turn **Allow access to messages** on. Without this, Meta will not deliver Instagram DMs to any external system, and nothing in the developer console will tell you.

Add the product

1. Meta app → **Add product** → **Instagram** → **Set up**.
2. Open **API setup with Instagram login** or **Instagram Graph API**, whichever your console shows.
3. Connect the Instagram account linked to your Page.
4. Go back to **Webhooks** in the sidebar, choose **Instagram** in the dropdown, and subscribe to `messages` and `messaging_postbacks` — the same fields as the Page, on a separate object.

Instagram needs no separate token. It uses the Page access token from step 6, because the Instagram account belongs to the Page.

6 Make a permanent access token

This is the step people skip, and the reason integrations silently stop working weeks later.

A token generated on the Messenger screen belongs to *you*, and expires. A **System User** token belongs to the *business* and does not. If you leave the company, or change your password, a personal token dies and the inbox goes quiet. Do this properly once.

1. Go to **business.facebook.com/settings**.
2. Left sidebar → **Users** → **System users**.
3. **Add** → name it "*CRM integration*" → role **Admin** → **Create system user**.
4. With it selected, click **Add assets**.
5. Choose **Pages**, tick your Page, and enable **Manage Page** (full control). Save.
6. Click **Generate new token**.
7. Choose your app from step 2.
8. Set **Token expiration** to **Never**.
9. Tick these permissions:
 - `pages_messaging` — send and receive Messenger messages
 - `pages_manage_metadata` — required for webhooks to work
 - `pages_read_engagement` — read the Page's conversations
 - `pages_show_list` — see which Pages you manage
 - `instagram_basic` and `instagram_manage_messages` — only if you did step 5
 - `leads_retrieval` — only if you run lead ads
10. Click **Generate token** and **copy it immediately**.

You get one chance to copy this

Meta shows the token once. Close the dialog without copying it and you cannot retrieve it — you must generate a new one, which invalidates the old. Paste it straight into the CRM at step 7.

The token starts with `EAAG` and is very long — several hundred characters. That is normal. Make sure you copy all of it; a truncated token fails in a way that looks like a permissions problem.

7 Enter everything into your CRM

Three values, one screen. This is the short step.

In the CRM, go to **Settings** → **Integrations** and find **Facebook & Instagram (Meta)**.

FIELD IN THE CRM	PASTE	FROM
Page access token (System User)	The EAAG... token	Step 6
App secret	The App Secret	Step 2 — Meta app → App settings → Basic
Verify token	Already set	You copied this out in step 3 — leave it alone

Click **Save** beside each field. Saved secrets show as `..... saved – leave blank to keep`, so you can edit one without retyping the others.

The badge at the top of the section changes from **Not set up** to **Connected** once the access token is saved.

"Connected" means "we have a token", not "it works"

The badge only reflects whether a token is stored. It cannot tell you the token is valid, that the Page is subscribed, or that Meta can reach you. Step 10 is the real test — do not skip it.

8 Add WhatsApp

A separate product, a separate number and a separate token — but the same app and the same webhook secret.

The number must be free of WhatsApp

If the number is currently registered to WhatsApp or WhatsApp Business on a phone, you must delete that account first (**WhatsApp** → **Settings** → **Account** → **Delete my account**) and wait a few minutes. There is no way around this, and doing it will erase that number's existing chat history.

Most businesses use a fresh number for the CRM and keep their existing WhatsApp on a phone for walk-in conversations.

1. Meta app → **Add product** → **WhatsApp** → **Set up**.
2. Select your Business account when prompted.
3. Meta creates a **test number** automatically. It only messages numbers you list, and cannot be used with customers — useful for step 10, not for going live.
4. Click **Add phone number** and enter your real business number.
5. Verify it by SMS or voice call.
6. Set the display name customers will see. Meta reviews this; avoid anything that reads like a promotion.

Point WhatsApp at the CRM

1. In the WhatsApp product, open **Configuration**.
2. Beside **Webhook**, click **Edit**.
3. **Callback URL**: the one from the CRM's **WhatsApp Business (Cloud API)** section — it ends in `/api/webhooks/whatsapp`. It is *not* the same URL as Messenger.
4. **Verify token**: the *same* verify token as step 3. WhatsApp and Messenger share it.
5. Click **Verify and save**, then **Manage** and subscribe to the `messages` field.

Get the two values the CRM needs

FIELD IN THE CRM	WHERE TO FIND IT
Phone number ID	WhatsApp → API Setup . It is a long number beside your phone number — <i>not</i> the phone number itself.
Access token (permanent, System User)	Generate as in step 6, adding <code>whatsapp_business_messaging</code> and <code>whatsapp_business_management</code> , and adding the WhatsApp account under Add assets .

Paste both into **Settings** → **Integrations** → **WhatsApp Business (Cloud API)** and save.

The 24-hour rule is WhatsApp's, not the CRM's

You may only send a free-form WhatsApp message within **24 hours** of the customer's last message. Outside that window WhatsApp refuses it, and the CRM will tell you so. To start a conversation, or to answer after 24 hours, you need a **message template** approved in WhatsApp Manager. This is a WhatsApp policy and applies to every system, not just this one.

9 Add Google reviews

Not a messaging channel, but it lands in the same place — new reviews arrive in the Social inbox so nobody has to remember to look.

This one is Google, not Meta, so none of the app, token or App Review work above applies. You need two values: an API key and your Place ID.

Create the API key

1. Go to **console.cloud.google.com** and sign in.
2. Create a project, or pick an existing one, from the selector at the top.
3. Left menu → **APIs & Services** → **Library**.
4. Search for **Places API (New)** and click **Enable**. Take care here: there is an older *Places API* as well, and a key enabled only for that one returns "this API is not enabled" with no hint that you picked the wrong entry of two nearly identical names.
5. Left menu → **APIs & Services** → **Credentials** → **Create credentials** → **API key**.
6. Copy the key. It starts with `AIza`.
7. Click **Edit API key** and, under **API restrictions**, restrict it to **Places API (New)**. An unrestricted key works everywhere, which is exactly the problem if it leaks.

Billing must be enabled, but the cost is negligible

Google requires a billing account on the project even inside the free tier, and will refuse the request without one. Reviews are fetched a few times a day for one place, which sits far below the free allowance. Set a budget alert if you want certainty.

Find your Place ID

1. Go to Google's **Place ID Finder** (search "Google Place ID Finder" — it is a page in Google's own documentation).
2. Search for your business by name and address.
3. Copy the Place ID from the marker. It starts with `ChIJ`.

Make sure you pick the exact listing customers review — a business with several branches has a Place ID *per branch*, and the wrong one silently pulls another branch's reviews.

Enter both into the CRM

FIELD IN THE CRM	VALUE
Places API key	The <code>AIza...</code> key
Place ID	The <code>ChIJ...</code> identifier

Both are required before anything appears — the section shows **Connected** only once each is set. New reviews then appear in the **Social inbox** within about six hours, with a push notification, and a **Reply on Google** link that opens the review in Google's own interface. Replies are posted there, not from the CRM: Google does not permit replying through the API.

Nothing appears at all?

Reviews are collected by a scheduled job, so the first batch is not instant — wait a few hours before concluding it is broken. If it is still empty after that, the usual causes are the older Places API enabled instead of Places API (New), no billing account on the project, or a Place ID for a different branch.

10 Test it end to end

Use a real phone that is not yours, and check both directions.

Do not test by messaging your own Page from the account that administers it. Meta treats that as a message to yourself and the results are misleading. Use a colleague's phone, or a personal account that has no role on the Page.

#	DO THIS	EXPECT
1	From the other phone, message your Page on Messenger	It appears in the CRM's Inbox within a few seconds, with the sender's name
2	Reply from the CRM	It arrives on the phone, and shows in the thread as yours
3	Send an Instagram DM to your business account	It appears in the Inbox, tagged Instagram
4	Reply to it from the CRM	It arrives in Instagram
5	WhatsApp your business number	It appears in the Inbox
6	Reply within 24 hours	It arrives on WhatsApp

Inbound and outbound fail for completely different reasons. Inbound failing is almost always the webhook — steps 3 and 4. Outbound failing is almost always the token or its permissions — step 6. Knowing which half broke tells you which step to revisit.

11 Go live: App Review

Everything above works only for you until Meta approves the app. This is the part that takes days, not minutes.

A new Meta app is in **Development mode**. In that state it can only message people who have a role on the app — you and anyone you add as a tester. Every test in step 10 will pass, and a real customer will still get nothing.

Add testers so you can trial it properly

Meta app → **App roles** → **Roles** → **Add people** → **Testers**. Each person must accept the invitation at developers.facebook.com/settings before it takes effect. Colleagues can then message you as real customers would.

Submit for review

1. Complete **App settings** → **Basic**: privacy policy URL, category, app icon. Review is refused without these.
2. Complete **Business verification** under your Business account — usually a registration document and a proof of address. This alone can take several days.
3. Go to **App Review** → **Permissions and features**.
4. Request **Advanced Access** for each permission from step 6 that you actually use.
5. For each one, record a short screencast showing a customer sending a message and your team answering it in the CRM. Reviewers reject vague submissions; show the actual flow.
6. Submit, then switch the app to **Live** with the toggle at the top of the console.

Common reasons a review is refused

The screencast does not show the permission being used. The privacy policy URL does not load. Business verification is incomplete. The described use does not match what the reviewer sees. All are fixable — read the rejection note, it says which one.

12 When something is wrong

Symptoms map to causes fairly reliably. Find yours.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS	FIX
"The URL couldn't be validated" when saving the webhook	The verify token does not match, or the URL is wrong	Re-copy both from Settings → Integrations. Check for a trailing space. The CRM answers this check and refuses a mismatch outright.
Webhook saved, but no messages arrive	Subscribed the app but not the Page	Messenger settings → Webhooks → Add subscriptions for your Page (step 4)
Messages arrived, then stopped	A temporary token expired	Replace it with a System User token set to Never expire (step 6)
Messages arrive; replies fail	Token lacks a permission	Regenerate with <code>pages_messaging</code> and, for Instagram, <code>instagram_manage_messages</code>
Works for you, not for customers	App is still in Development mode	Complete App Review and switch to Live (step 11)
Instagram DMs never appear	"Allow access to messages" is off, or the account is not Professional	Instagram app → Settings → Privacy → Messages (step 5)
WhatsApp reply refused	Outside the 24-hour window	Use an approved template, or wait for the customer to message again
Cannot add the WhatsApp number	It is still registered to the WhatsApp app	Delete that WhatsApp account, wait, retry (step 8)

If Meta reaches you but nothing is accepted

The CRM checks that every incoming webhook is signed with your App Secret. If the secret is wrong, Meta's requests arrive and are rejected — so the developer console shows delivery succeeding while the CRM shows nothing. If inbound has never worked and the webhook validated cleanly, re-copy the **App Secret** from **App settings** → **Basic**. It is the one value whose mistake looks like silence rather than an error.

13 Keeping it working

Four habits that prevent the failures that take longest to diagnose.

Never use a personal token. If the person who created it leaves, changes their password, or loses their Page role, messages stop. System User tokens survive all three.

Keep the System User assigned to the Page. Removing it from the Page in Business settings kills the token instantly, and it is an easy thing to do while tidying permissions.

Rotate the App Secret if it is ever exposed. Meta app → App settings → Basic → **Reset**, then update it in Settings → Integrations immediately. Between those two actions, inbound messages are refused.

Re-run step 10 after any change in Meta. Adding a product, changing permissions or regenerating a token can quietly break one direction. The six-line test takes two minutes.

If you change your CRM address

The webhook URL is tied to the address your CRM is served from. If that changes, update both callback URLs in the Meta console — **Webhooks** for Messenger and Instagram, and **WhatsApp** → **Configuration** — and verify each again. Messages sent to the old address are not queued; they are lost.

Who to ask

Anything on **developers.facebook.com** or **business.facebook.com** — app creation, tokens, permissions, App Review — is Meta's, and Meta's support can see things you cannot. Anything on the **Settings** → **Integrations** screen, or a message that reached Meta but not your Inbox, is ours. Say which side of the line you are on and you will get to the right person faster.